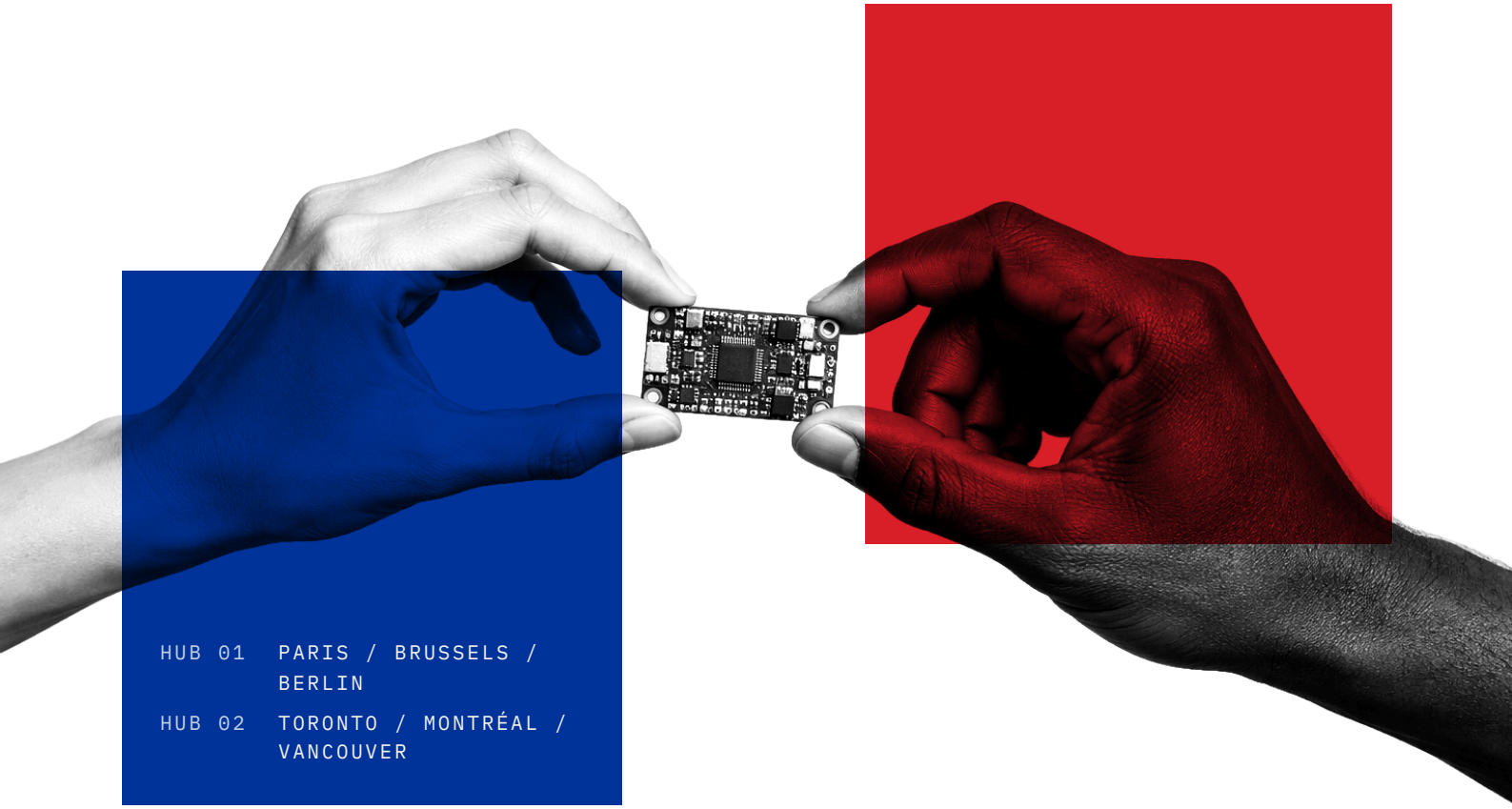


EU CAN INNOVATE

EU-Canada Digital Bridge Hackathon

PREPARED BY
Krishen Mertens
Berlin

STATUS
Early-stage draft, seeking feedback and expressions of interest

DATE
November 2026

SECTION 01

The opportunity, and the case for acting now

On September 16, 2026, European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen proposed that Canada become the European Union's first associate member, with Prime Minister Mark Carney present in the chamber in Strasbourg.

At their summit in Montréal on October 30, 2026, the two sides launched an Alliance for the Future, with work areas spanning digital and research technologies, critical raw materials and energy, and security and preparedness. They aim to define an ever-closer association of Canada to the EU by the 2027 summit.

We see strong political intent and mutual commitment. What we need now is a visible, working demonstration at the level where cooperation is actually built: among the engineers, founders, designers and researchers who would have to deliver it.

That foundation already exists today. Canada has been associated with Pillar II of Horizon Europe, the Union's research and innovation programme, since 2024, covering climate, energy, the digital economy and health. In Montréal, both sides committed to work toward Canada's participation in future European research and innovation programmes.

A legal and funding structure for EU-Canada innovation cooperation is therefore in place. This initiative sets out to make it tangible and visible.

EU CAN Innovate brings practitioners from across the Union and from Canada into one working format, builds prototypes against real, pre-scoped problems, and documents what comes out of it.

> This works, regardless of how or whether a formal political arrangement is ever finalised.

POSITIONING

SECTION 02

Four focus areas

Mapped onto the work areas of the EU-Canada Alliance for the Future, so the work stays relevant to the political process without depending on it.

T/01

Technology

AI, compute and shared digital tooling across the two research ecosystems.

T/02

Critical raw materials

Supply-chain transparency and circularity, from extraction to recycling.

T/03

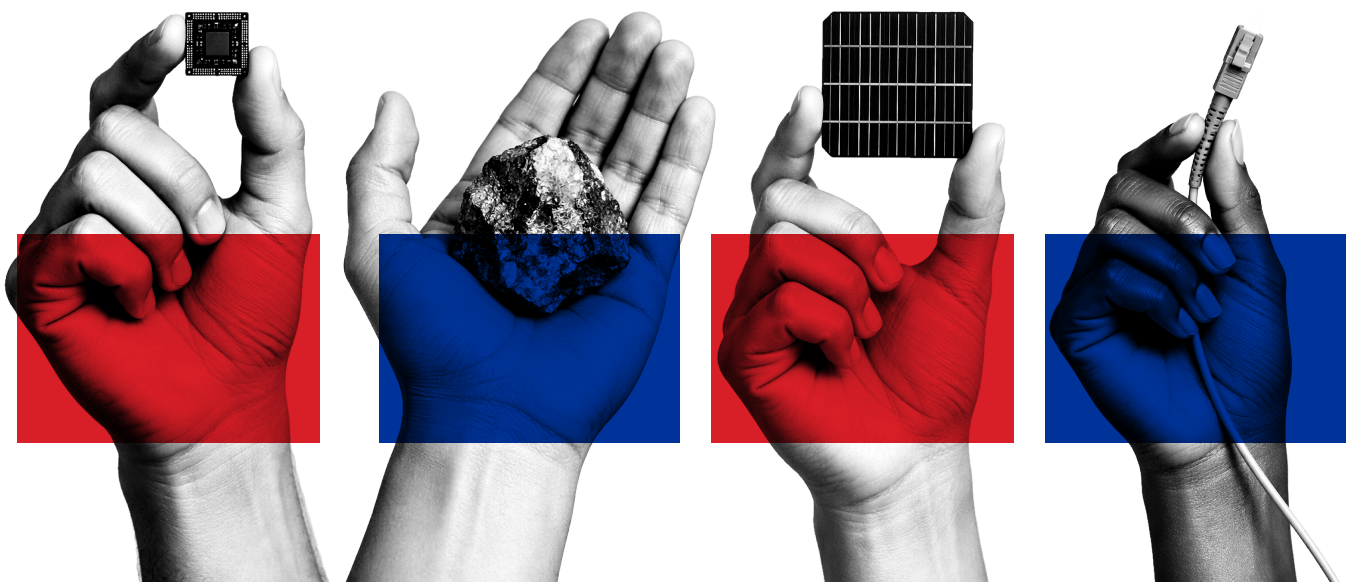
Energy

Clean energy, grids, battery storage and the protection of energy infrastructure.

T/04

Resilience

Critical infrastructure, subsea cables and cybersecurity (excluding defence and dual-use).



SECTION 03

Two rooms, one event

MODEL	Hybrid. One European hub (Paris, Brussels or Berlin) live-linked to one Canadian hub (Toronto, Montréal or Vancouver), both to be confirmed with partners. Open to participants from across EU member states.
DURATION	Two to three days. Open to discussion with partners.
LANGUAGE	English.
CADENCE	The first edition of a recurring, documented format, not a one-off. Outputs are meant to be citable over time.

Who we want in the room

01
Developers and engineers
From both research ecosystems.

02
Startup founders
Early-stage, building in the four tracks.

03
Designers
Product, interaction and industrial.

04
Researchers
University staff and graduate students.

05
Corporate innovation
As mentors and challenge sponsors.

06
Institutional presence
Parliament, missions or Commission, as observers.



SECTION 04

From prototype to impact

Output quality depends on the quality of the challenge behind it. Every track is scoped in advance with a real problem owner: an industry partner, a research consortium, or an organisation already working across the EU-Canada relationship. Never a generic, open-ended prompt.

01

A named challenge owner

Each track carries a genuine, unsolved problem and an organisation that owns it.

02

Teams matched in advance

Skills matched to the challenge, EU-Canada pairing built into pre-event matching rather than left to chance.

03

A committed next step

A pilot conversation, an accelerator place, or at minimum a scheduled debrief, agreed before the event.

THE AIM

A credible starting point for continued work, not a demo that ends when the room empties.

INDICATIVE EVENT FLOW

DAY 1

Kick-off

Challenge owners brief all teams live across both hubs. Matched teams meet and settle their approach.

DAY 2

Build

Teams prototype with mentors in their hub and sync across the Atlantic in the shared window.

DAY 3

Demo

Teams present to their challenge owners, who confirm the agreed next step for each track.

SECTION 05

Phases

01	Now – Dec 2026	**Outreach and feedback** Share this note with potential partners, gather input, refine scope and format.
02	Early 2027	**Scoping and commitments** Confirm challenge owners, secure hosting and co-organising partners, fix both host cities.
03	Mid 2027	**First edition** The event runs across both hubs.
04	After	**Documentation and follow-through** Record outcomes, follow up on challenge results, plan a second edition.

Deliberately decoupled from the EU-Canada political calendar. The pace is set to produce a solid first edition, not to chase a negotiation milestone.

SECTION 06

Who we are looking to engage

Rather than naming individual organisations at this stage, the initiative is seeking conversations across these categories. Specific approaches are being made directly and separately.

A	Bilateral chambers of commerce and trade associations active in EU-Canada relations
B	Cleantech and innovation accelerator networks in the EU and Canada
C	Public funding and research bodies connected to Horizon Europe or equivalent Canadian programmes
D	Universities and research institutions with relevant technical expertise
E	Diplomatic missions and EU institutions, as observers or supporters rather than organisers

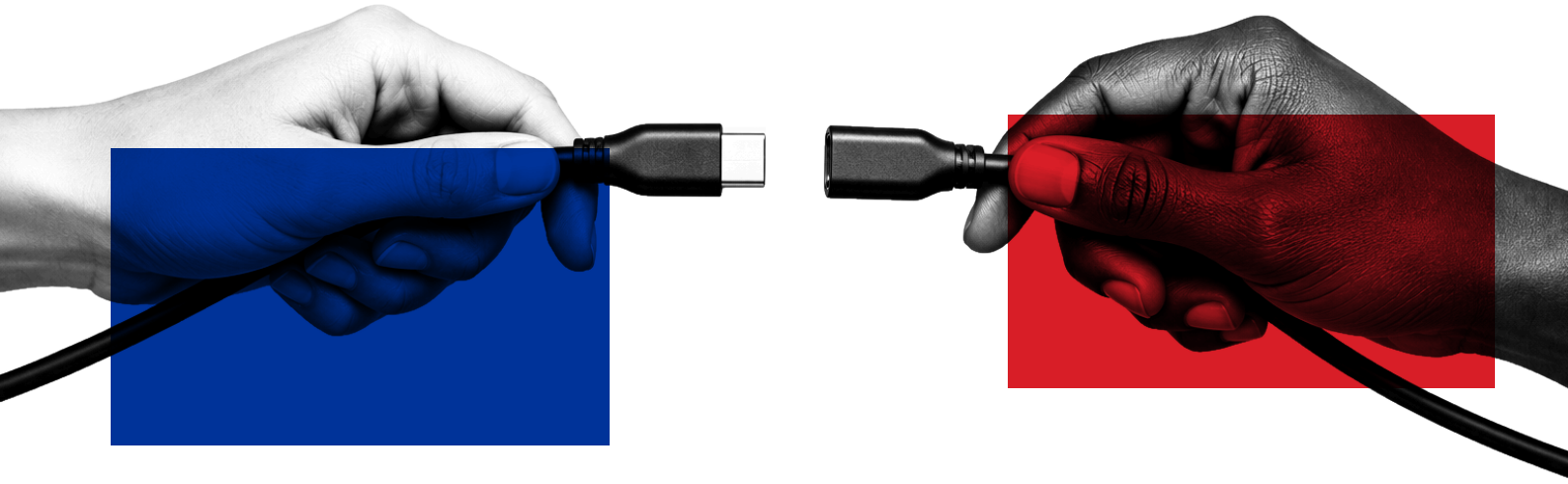
Four questions for you

01 Does this fill a gap, or overlap with something you already run?

02 A standalone hackathon, a track inside an existing event, or another model?

03 What timing realistically fits the pace of the political process?

04 Which of the four tracks matters most to your stakeholders?



LET US TALK

ABOUT THE INITIATOR

An independent initiative led by Krishen Mertens, a Berlin-based design and innovation professional working at the intersection of technology and sustainability. Not undertaken on behalf of, or with the backing of, any employer.

PURPOSE OF THIS DOCUMENT

An early-stage concept note, not a finalised event proposal. It exists to test whether the idea resonates, to gather honest feedback on scope and feasibility, and to identify co-organisers, hosts and challenge partners.

Krishen Mertens
Berlin, Germany

LINKEDIN
linkedin.com/in/krishenmertens

EMAIL
krishen.mertens@googlemail.com